

When Another Way Becomes Possible: Feeling the Situation Differently Is Not the Same as Producing a New Option

Human-readable companion to When an Alternative Becomes Possible: Lived Reorganization and Action-Option Generation Under a Common Perturbation History

Human-readable companion to “When an Alternative Becomes Possible: Lived Reorganization and Action-Option Generation Under a Common Perturbation History.” This companion preserves the scientific claims, limits, and contraction rules of the source manuscript while foregrounding the ordinary human question that motivated it. It is not a separate research contribution.

Abstract

A person can understand advice, repeat it, and even recommend it to somebody else while the suggested action still does not appear as a live option from inside their own situation. At other times they can name an alternative without reporting any corresponding change in how the situation feels organized. Pull turns that ordinary distinction into a bounded measurement problem. It separates task-relevant lived organization, denoted Φ , from standardized option generation, denoted G . Both are sampled after controlled histories of evidence, but they are measured on separate branches because asking one question can change the later response. The primary question is not whether Φ and G ever dissociate at one endpoint. Different thresholds or nonlinear readouts of one shared underlying response coordinate could create apparent dissociation. The experiment therefore asks progressively stronger questions: does current explicit evidence already suffice; can one flexible shared coordinate predict both response classes; if richer response geometry is needed, is that richness already required by Φ alone; and only then, does G add held-out intervention-response geometry beyond the validated Φ structure? The proposal is a measurement architecture, not a mechanism, theory of therapy, or claim about causal order.

1. The motivating experience: “I knew that already, but now I can see another way”

Some advice is semantically understood long before it becomes usable from inside the problem. A person can explain why an alternative makes sense for someone else while still failing to produce that same alternative when asked what they themselves could do. Later, after more evidence or a changed history, the words may be unchanged but the situation no longer seems organized in the same way.

The reverse is also possible. Someone can list another action while reporting that the situation still feels exactly as it did before. Pull therefore refuses to use phrases such as “it finally clicked,” “it became possible,” or “I finally got it” as if they named one event. Those phrases can mix changed meaning, option generation, preference, intention, action, confidence, or outcome.

a changed lived organization $\neq$ a generated action option

2. The paper owns two response properties, not a hidden stage

The experiment isolates two measured relations. Φ (Φ) is a frozen, report-derived representation of task-relevant relational or meaning organization in immediate experience. The primary Φ coding excludes explicit action-option identity so that “I thought of leaving” cannot itself define the experiential variable. G is standardized option generation: under a fixed prompt, does the participant produce the prelearned target action, with the primary measure focusing on first production.

Neither variable is treated as a hidden mechanism. G records what is generated under the measurement operation; it does not prove that the same option was silently present beforehand. Φ is evidence about task-relevant lived organization; the report is not equated with phenomenality itself.

Object	What it means here	What it does not establish
Φ (Φ)	Immediate task-relevant relational/meaning organization represented from open report under a frozen coding rule.	A unique neural mechanism, causal route, or action option.

Object	What it means here	What it does not establish
G	Standardized generation of the prelearned target option, primarily whether it is produced first.	That the option existed before the probe, was preferred, selected, attempted, or realized.
E	Explicit current environmental/evidential judgment.	That the history leading to E is irrelevant for Phi or G.
M	Prior measurement/probe history used to model carryover.	A psychological stage or latent state.

3. A possible action, a generated option, and a chosen action are different things

Option-generation research already establishes that people may have to produce candidate actions before choosing among them. Pull inherits that distinction. A physically available action is not automatically a generated option, and a generated option is not automatically a chosen action.

This matters because the human intuition behind the paper is easy to overstate. The experiment cannot prove that an option suddenly became an internal candidate at some hidden moment. It can ask a narrower, directly measurable question: after a specified history, can the participant produce the target option under a standardized generation demand?

4. Why Phi and G are measured on separate branches

Directly asking “how does this feel?” or “what could you do?” can change what happens next. Repeated probing can focus attention, rehearse a response, create new semantic organization, or make the target route more available. The experiment therefore does not repeatedly sample Phi and G from the same critical episode and then pretend the probes were passive.

Instead, matched perturbation histories are followed by different randomized measurement branches. One trial samples immediate open report for Phi, another samples standardized option generation, and other branches sample E, generic-state comparators, or delayed/reconstruction controls. Prior probe history M is recorded so the model can test whether the apparent geometry is really a carryover artifact.

The intuitive question may sound temporal - did experience change before the option became available? The proposed assay does not observe same-episode simultaneity or temporal order. It compares intervention-response structure across matched branches.

5. The experiment asks increasingly difficult compression questions

The central analysis does not jump straight from one dissociation to “two systems.” It begins with simpler explanations and only preserves richer structure if the simpler models fail on held-out intervention conditions.

Question	Scientific test	If it survives
Is current explicit evidence enough?	H_E: once E is known, do different evidence histories still predict Phi or G?	If yes, history factorization may matter beyond current explicit judgment. If no, richer history can contract.
Can one flexible shared coordinate explain both?	H_1D: Phi and G may have different nonlinear readouts, thresholds, scaling, and noise but share one participant-level perturbation direction.	If adequate, apparent endpoint dissociation does not require richer joint response geometry.
Does the joint response require richer geometry?	H_2R relaxes the one-direction restriction.	A global richer fit shows only that the whole response vector needs more geometry. It does not yet show that G adds structure beyond Phi.

The shared-coordinate competitor is intentionally flexible. A one-dimensional relation can produce very different-looking outputs when response functions are nonlinear or thresholded. The paper therefore treats a flexible H_1D as a serious conventional rival rather than designing a weak straw man.

6. The most important repair: richer joint geometry is not automatically a Phi/G dissociation

Phi is not a single rating. Its frozen representation may contain several reliable relational contrasts. That means Phi alone could require more than one intervention-response direction. If the global H_2R model beats H_1D, the extra geometry might therefore belong entirely to the experiential measurement rather than to a separate G dimension.

Pull addresses that attribution problem in a nested sequence. First estimate the response subspace required by Phi alone, S_Phi. Then give G its own threshold, scaling, intercept, and noise while constraining its intervention dependence to remain inside S_Phi. This is the contained-G model. Only after that comparator fails on held-out conditions does an incremental-G model allow G to add an intervention-response direction outside the Phi structure.

Phi-only structure -> contained G -> incremental G

A specifically Phi/G richer-geometry claim therefore requires more than a global model win. The Phi-only structure must be established prospectively, contained G must be materially insufficient on held-out intervention conditions, and incremental G must improve held-out prediction while the same safeguards remain satisfied.

7. Four gates stop measurement artifacts from masquerading as structure

Gate	What has to be true	What happens if it fails
Phenomenology gate	Immediate reports contain reproducible task-relevant relational/meaning structure not exhausted by simpler semantic or generic-state coding.	The stronger Phi claim contracts to the simpler reconstructable description.
Generation gate	The target action is learned before critical trials but is not supplied by the perturbation or probe.	G contracts toward ordinary route selection, retrieval, or prompt-driven production.
Perturbation gate	Cue diagnosticity/strength A and repetition N retain meaningful independent intervention geometry.	The intended factorized history comparison collapses.
Carryover gate	The principal response geometry remains after the declared probe-history adjustment M and prospective anti-carryover checks.	The intended P-response surface is not identified; carryover cannot simply be absorbed as "higher dimension."

Semantic-yoked and delayed reconstruction controls add another protection. If delayed reconstruction or a simpler semantic coding reproduces the confirmatory Phi signal without material loss, the stronger lived-organization interpretation should shrink rather than being defended rhetorically.

8. What the possible outcomes actually say

- If E predicts both Phi and G across matched histories, H_E survives and the richer history factorization is unnecessary for those responses.
- If history matters but flexible H_1D predicts Phi and G, the measurements can look different while still being compatible with one shared response coordinate.
- If H_2R wins globally but G remains adequately contained in the validated Phi subspace, the result is Phi-internal richer structure - not a specifically Phi/G separation.
- Only if contained G is materially insufficient and incremental G adds held-out predictive geometry beyond Phi does the experiment support the stronger response-geometry distinction.
- If any measurement, perturbation, or carryover gate fails, the architecture contracts before a stronger dimensional interpretation is made.

9. What Pull deliberately does not claim

The paper does not identify readiness, resistance, personality, psychotherapy response, or a hidden action-generation gate. It does not claim that Phi causes G, that G causes Phi, or that they change at the same time. It does

not infer a latent candidate state from later generation, and it does not interpret model dimensionality as the number of ontological psychological systems.

Persistence and later realization are also outside the primary claim. Immediate reorganization may fade; generated options may never be chosen; chosen actions may never be implemented. Those are separate questions and remain separate by design.

10. The point of Pull

The human question is simple: can the situation become organized differently for a person without the same change appearing in what action they can produce, or can a new option be produced while the situation still feels organized in the old way? Pull does not answer that question by naming two hidden modules. It builds a measurement architecture capable of discovering whether one preregistered shared response coordinate is enough.

The strongest result would still be modest: under the declared histories and measurements, G would require intervention-response geometry beyond that already needed for Phi. If established response-coherence models, semantic reconstruction, carryover, or one flexible shared coordinate do the job, the paper is designed to contract.

Selected References

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The source manuscript contains the complete reference list.